For example, CMS Business School at Jain University runs a post-graduate diploma in aerospace safety management and accident investigation with the Indian Air Force, designed for serving defence officers.

"It is a niche, highly specialised programme," says Karthik Kudkuli, Assistant Professor of Aviation and Aerospace Management and the institutional lead for the programme. The school plans to extend the programme to civil aviation professionals as well.

RESEARCH TO THE RESCUE

The second big shift is taking place in research and consulting. The *BT*-MDRA survey data shows a significant increase in average revenue from research and consulting assignments across top 100 B-schools. The most dramatic change is at the top: among the top 10, average revenue from research and consulting rose from about ₹5.3 crore in 2025 to nearly ₹20.9 crore in 2026. Among the top 25, the average has risen from about ₹3.5 crore to ₹9.7 crore.

"Investment in research has increased by 34% with focus on faculty-initiated research projects and procuring tech stacks for research," says Varun Nagaraj, Professor of Information Management and Analytics and Dean of S.P. Jain Institute of Management & Research (SPJIMR), Mumbai.

Meanwhile, there has been a huge increase in government-sponsored research and consultancy among the top 25 schools. This means more public money for research, innovation, and large-scale policy initiatives.

Great Lakes' Neti points to the Anusandhan National Research Foundation and the ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation Fund. Metri says there is a rise in demand for evidence-based policy inputs, impact assessment, capacity building, and supporting rural transformation, climate resilience, infrastructure, digital governance, and skilling programmes. Examples include IIM Nagpur's work with MITRA, the Maharashtra government's village-development initiative, and its Centre of Excellence for Heat Resilience. These are not just academic studies. They sit at the intersection of research, consulting, public policy and implementation.

The corporate picture is more complicated. Industry-sponsored research and consultancy have contracted, reflecting an environment where companies are scrutinising spending more closely. "The corporate consulting and sponsored-research pipeline is becoming more selective," says Ashita Aggarwal, Professor of Marketing at SPJIMR.

Companies increasingly want shorter projects with direct connection to business outcomes rather than long-duration research whose commercial payoff is difficult to quantify.

CSR money is moving in a similar direction. Aggarwal says companies are increasingly favouring visible, immediate-impact areas such as skilling, health and livelihoods rather than funding a research centre that may take years to show results.

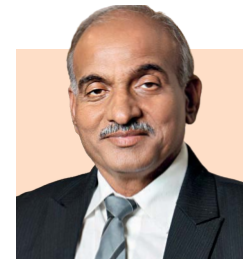
Metri says the focus is shifting from standalone assignments to co-created, impact-linked partnerships. One example is IIM Nagpur's collaboration with ONGC Green, covering research, policy inputs and leadership development around green hydrogen, carbon markets and e-mobility. Such partnerships do not always appear neatly under a conventional "consultancy revenue" heading. The old categories of research, consulting, executive education and industry engagement are beginning to overlap.

And that is why the revenue numbers need to be read carefully. Preeta George, Professor of Eco-



"Rapid developments in technology, such as AI and fintech, require continuous reskilling of the workforce"

U. DINESH KUMAR
DIRECTOR-IN-CHARGE, IIM BANGALORE



"The academic revenue was ₹100 crore with ₹37 crore coming from executive education, MDPs, consultancy and related activities"

BHIMARAYA METRI
DIRECTOR, IIM NAGPUR